

Humans, Sustainability, and Endangered Animals

We've all heard of the IUCN's Red List or endangered species at some point. And whenever that topic surfaces, some pretty common names show up: tigers, rhinos, and orcas are usually mentioned, but that's just the tip of the iceberg. What may be more distressing is that we, as human beings, have a part to play in the harming of these animals. But we also have one in their resurrection.

Deforestation:

To be real, this is our main harmful act. We enter forests and wipe them clean of trees for our need for wood. We use said wood for copious purposes, ranging from making paper to providing fuel to building houses. We justify the actions easily, whether aware or not of the impacts it leaves on forest ecosystems, because at the end of the day, this is *our* planet and we must have the right to use the resources it provides for us. But does that mean we also get to strip every other species of the same right?

To begin with, forests are a habitat for many organisms. Animals, fungi, and plants are the most noticeable, be it the birds living on trees, the mushrooms growing on their trunks or even the trees themselves. In the act of killing the trees, we erase species' homes, leaving them with no shelter and making them vulnerable to predators. They are not meant to be this exposed to hunters, and thus an imbalance is caused; the prey is hunted more, and their numbers decrease, eventually leading to predator numbers decreasing and, overall, the food web of the ecosystem is in shambles. One change affects another. This chain reaction begins because we cut down trees. Let us look into it in detail.

In swamped, old-growth forests lived a species of woodpecker, the Ivory-Billed woodpecker. The trees in its habitat were cut down for timber, and it lost its home, making it much more exposed to the Red-tailed hawk. Plus, this woodpecker fed on insects that also lived in the trees. The loss of food also contributed to the decline of the unfortunate birds. The loss of a place to live made it much harder for woodpecker species to find mates, and therefore the population could not grow; the Ivory-Billed woodpecker is now universally considered extinct. Since the 1940s, actually.

However, not all endangered species are animals. The Ghost Orchid in the swamped forests of Florida is currently in decline. This organism is a plant that grows on the bases of trees. The loss of these trees has a rather obvious impact on these plants, forming a direct link as to why deforestation leads to their deaths.

Most of us are unaware of the harm done when trees are cut down, mainly because we are not there ourselves or because when we write on a sheet of paper, it is hard to think about the plants and animals that died for the sake of it. When we sit around a campfire roasting marshmallows, the habitats destroyed are not the first thing on our minds.

Resources:

Our human need for resources both directly and indirectly harms several different species. The need for resources can range from directly hunting animals to harming them through land made for mines.

A great example of hunting animals for resources would be our hunting of elephants. The ivory in elephant tusks is used for a variety of things, such as carvings, jewelry, and luxury items throughout history. This led to widespread hunting of these elephants, especially the African bush elephants, living in sub-Saharan Africa. Because it is the largest elephant species, it naturally has the highest yield of ivory in tusks.

Another example is the White Rhinoceros, which was heavily hunted for the keratin in its horn, which was said to have medical benefits. However, scientifically, there is not much use of keratin when ingested. The White Rhinoceros was also the largest species of rhino at the time, and was reduced to a limited number of individuals. Sadly, this shows that the hunting of rhinos was in vain, and that all those deaths could have been avoided.

Moving on to the indirect effects of resource seeking, we build many mines all around the world for underground metals such as iron, copper, or gold. We need to clear up a lot of space for these operations, destroying a large number of habitats for our own benefit. When we dig oil wells and bring in huge machinery for extraction, just the noise is enough to drive animals away from the site.

Illegal Hunting and Game:

A highly important reason for the loss of many animals is poaching, whether to illegally sell or for the "fun" of it. Many animals have been poached in our lifetime and yet the ban placed did little to prevent these deaths, only motivating the hunters to learn, create and practice more unethical methods.

To illustrate, let us look at the Green Peafowl. An endangered species of bird that was hunted for its meat and beautiful feathers. This species endured massive shooting, which greatly decreased its numbers.

A more famous example is the Dodo bird. A flightless bird on the island of Mauritius. Less than a century after the arrival of humans on the island, the dodos were hunted to extinction. They were killed for their meat by humans, which was rather easy considering the birds lived for a long time without human predators, so they did not fear them nor expect them to be so vile. In addition, highlighting the fact that they are flightless birds, they could not fly out of reach nor escape the human hand. Only about as far as their duck-like limbs could get them. Another factor that led to the extinction of the Dodo was other invasive species, such as ship rats that accompanied humans on their sailing ships and eventually took the mistreated Dodo bird as prey once they settled on the island.

One final example would be the South China tiger, which was hunted for a very long time for its bones and skin, which are considered a luxury in illegal trade. This species of tiger is now considered Critically Endangered by the International Union of Conservation of Nature, and even extinct in the wild. In fact, most tiger species are considered threatened, including the Bengal tiger, Malayan tiger, and Amur tiger species, all hunted for the same reasons.

What Can We Do?

This is the sensitive part. Most of us might not be able to do anything. For example, it is not in our hands to bring back dead animal species or to resurrect trees that were killed for wood. So, we usually feel sorry for the animals and dismiss the topic. That is where we go wrong. The least we can do is spread awareness to our family, friends, and communities. We must try to make sure that someone with the capacity to help will at least hear of it.

For those of us who want to do more than just spread the word, there are several things we can do. To begin with, we can use resources more sustainably; burning less wood, using less fuel, or wasting less food. To buy only what we will use may not seem like much, but it actually helps a lot in the long run.

If a more hands-on activity is desired, volunteering to help in organizations could mean a lot to the endangered species. This volunteer work could lead to planting trees or tending to animals and plants in captivity. Plus, any volunteer work could be added to a college or job application for more success and confidence in securing said college or job. Two birds with one ~~stone~~ scone.

Finally, if one is truly committed to saving wildlife and has a passion for it, then not only can they participate in temporary volunteer work, but why not major and build a life around it? Students can take Conservation Biology as a major in many universities and build their life around helping endangered species, tending to the harmed and providing them with shelter.

Or, if one wishes not to work hands-on but has a desire to help, then donations and investments would surely help many startups and projects build captive holdings, seed banks, and rewilding programs.

Why Help?

If this article did not at least ignite a bit of humanity and sympathy towards other living species, here are several reasons we should try to save threatened species.

Firstly, several species that are dying are known as 'Keystone species.' This means that most food webs revolve around them. These species are usually the producers at the bottom of the food chain or the apex predators at the top, because they keep it in check. The death of these organisms could throw the ecosystem off balance.

Secondly, we have to be careful of our actions because even if we, as humans, are the most advanced species technologically, that does not mean we should mistreat the other organisms.

We must coexist with them so that future generations can do the same. So, we have a moral obligation to help the endangered species.

Thirdly, if all else has failed, there is much left for us to learn from the organisms we have. There are many medicines, healing herbs and cures in plants just waiting to be discovered. Wasting that potential because we could not control our actions would be a great shame.

Recent Advancements in Conservation:

De-extinction is one of the most exciting topics scientists are exploring as of now. Technology has gotten really advanced in the genetic area, and this could be used to resurrect certain extinct species. The leading methods are genetic engineering of close relatives, selective breeding, and cloning of intact cells.

These methods are being used for several different species, including the Woolly mammoth, the aforementioned Dodo, and carrier pigeons. Only once has this kind of resurrection worked, for the Pyrenean ibex in 2003, but the organism soon died of respiratory issues. Of course, this was over two decades ago, and advancements have made a huge boost forward; this means much more could be achieved in the near future.

To conclude, there are many things we can do as a community to act sustainably towards the species we share this world with. Their future depends on the choices we make today. If we work together to protect wildlife and preserve the environment, we can ensure that future generations inherit a planet rich in life, not one diminished by preventable loss.